

Reliability Ranking Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Cross-AOK • 25-35 min

Category	Cross-AOK	Time	25-35 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	reliability-ranking

Big idea: Certainty varies across kinds of knowledge.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Reliability Ranking Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Reliability Ranking Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Knowledge claims ranked by certainty, usefulness, and risk if wrong. Name the AOK, the method being used, and the standard of evidence you would apply.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Reliability Ranking Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A second ranking after students learn the method behind each claim. Name the AOK, the method being used, and the standard of evidence you would apply.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Reliability Ranking Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A discussion on whether reliability means the same thing in every AOK. Name the AOK, the method being used, and the standard of evidence you would apply.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Certainty varies across kinds of knowledge.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Reliability Ranking Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Reliability Ranking Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Is certainty the best measure of knowledge?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Knowledge claims ranked by certainty, usefulness, and risk if wrong.
- A second ranking after students learn the method behind each claim.
- A discussion on whether reliability means the same thing in every AOK.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Cross-AOK.

Activity Steps

1. Give cards such as: "The angles in a Euclidean triangle sum to 180 degrees", "Smoking increases lung cancer risk", "This poem expresses grief", "Most people conform under group pressure", "This painting is beautiful".
2. Students rank claims from most to least certain.
3. They then rank from most to least useful.
4. Compare the two rankings.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Is certainty the best measure of knowledge?
- Can uncertain knowledge still be valuable?
- Are mathematical truths more valuable because they are more certain?

Knowledge Questions

- Is certainty the best measure of knowledge?
- Can uncertain knowledge still be valuable?
- Are mathematical truths more valuable because they are more certain?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with knowledge claims ranked by certainty, usefulness, and risk if wrong. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...